



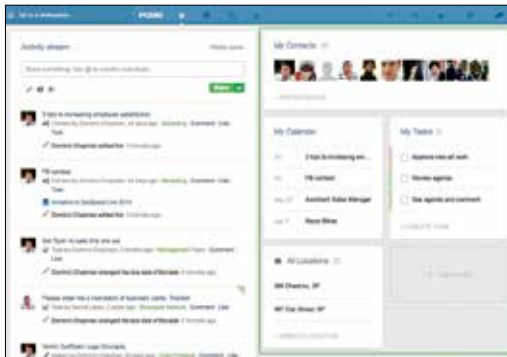
Philips SceneSwitch
Philips' new SceneSwitch bulbs offer three different light modes
<http://dgit.in/PhlpScSwth>



LeEco's LeSEE funded
China's LeEco has raised \$1.08 Billion for building its concept-sedan electric sports car.
<http://dgit.in/LeSee1B>

Smart SoHo

pointed. Instead of integrations, they have a mini app within the platform which does different things. So when you're just setting up a workspace on Podio, you'll have a blank canvas. You then add the functionality you want for your organisations by installing the necessary apps. There are some really



Podio is more of an enterprise-based platform

good apps made by Podio themselves which provide basic productivity and project management tools. The developer community is pretty active and Podio are ready to provide custom solutions for your business. Podio works more or less like Facebook, but for work. You can create and comment on status updates, share updates regarding projects or people and of course manage advanced projects. Podio integrates with Google Calendar and lets you sync all your events to your devices. This works well for managers and people who assign tasks.

You can set membership levels of users and have complete control over the teams. Podio also offers discounted rates for Students and Non Profits, and is a non expensive option to custom made collaboration software.

Hip Chat

Hip Chat as the name says, is a cloud-based collaboration software that has chat as its main focus. A team has multiple rooms each of which can be set for a specific purpose. A large team can have several rooms such as marketing, development, IT support, web design etc. It is very similar to Slack, and has the ability to send files, links, and add integrations to make your experience

better. Hip Chat does not bring anything new to the table, and promises to eliminate email completely for your organisation. Hip Chat did not do well initially, but after a good interface overhaul, it looks promising, but still struggles to differentiate itself from Slack.

Flock

Flock is India's answer to killer productivity. Honing the Make In India badge, Flock is a natively developed solution to killer office productivity. Flock claims to be much faster and more efficient than Slack. With optimised search and well-placed hamburger menus. Apps seem to work better in Flock and their APIs integrate much deeper into the platform than Slack.

It has integrations which can help you have video and audio calls from within the app itself and even share your screen. It has the usual features of tasks, to-dos, reminders, document collaboration and polling. Flock is relatively a new player in the game and even has dedicated sections on its website, trying hard to explain why it is different from Slack. We'll have to see how well they market amongst the already saturated market in collaboration apps.

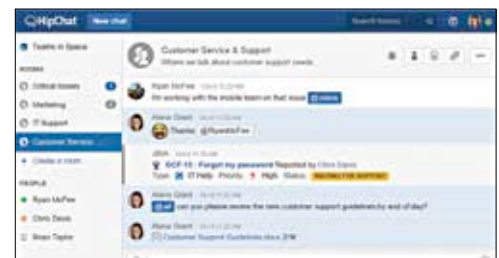
Asana

Asana on the other hand is a task management platform. It is mainly targeted at managerial people who love assigning tasks to juniors, while integrating with most collaboration platforms. This too works to eliminate email. Asana has APIs which integrate with Evernote, Drive, Jira, Dropbox etc. Teams create their own workspaces, workspaces have projects and projects have tasks. These tasks are then assigned to members in your team and each person can see the tasks assigned and mark it as complete or perform actions based on the task. Asana is good if you're a part of a lot of teams. It helps you switch easily between pro-

jects and notifies you if the state of any task or project changes. Asana is very complex to set up, with a lot of scope for customisation, but is a real workhorse once you get it up and running.

Verdict

We have detailed all the major players in the online cloud-based collaboration platforms, most of which are free to use and require you to pay for additional features. There is no perfect solution to online productivity that exists right now and you'll usually end up using a combination of products to suit your needs. The most common combination would be to use Slack + Trello/Asana and their suite of mobile apps to keep you annoyed with notifications on the go. Evernote is another popular tool which isn't exactly targeted as a collaboration app, but it is used in more ways than you can imagine. With Apple pitching the new iWork suite of applications with live collaboration, it can be considered along with Google Docs as a collaboration tool, but



Hip Chat is a great alternative to email

their chat and integrations are often very poor or don't work very well.

The biggest problem with these productivity apps is not that there are several of them which do the exact same thing, but that users are very reluctant to adopt new software and platforms. So the biggest hurdle you're going to be facing is getting the users to adapt to these new tools. Apart from that if your organisation is not using any such tools, you'll need to train the employees to use the new tools. Last thing you'd want is for only a few members of the team using the new tools. Your productivity will get destroyed if it is not implemented properly.